

Session 1: Background and Summary of the Letter

Key Takeaways

- The New Testament epistle writers address churches in specific cities or geographical regions, all of which have their own characters, problems, cultural issues, strengths, and weaknesses.
- Paul's aim in the letter is to bring the Corinthian church to maturity in its thinking and practices.
- Honor-shame cultures, like that of the Corinthian church, place particular stress on tradition, relationships, and hierarchy.
- The church at Corinth has reverted to cultural norms of tradition, relationship, and hierarchy, which also means segregation and division.

Background and Summary of the Letter

All Scripture was written in a particular place at a particular time by particular people. And all of Scripture is revelatory for us to understand the nature of God and his purposes for his people. So what we read in the Bible is both particular to its time and has universal import.

But God's revelation comes to us in and through the particular, presented through an existing cultural lens. This is true of 1 Corinthians, and perhaps even more so than with other texts.

Epistles are written to specific churches in specific cities or geographical regions, all of which have their own characters, problems, cultural issues, strengths, and weaknesses. Attempting to understand some of these is a challenge for us as we piece together clues from the text.

Approaching the Text: Reading a Letter

In order to understand what this very specific letter written to a group of people 2,000 years ago might say to us, we need to locate the letter in its own context. This is true of all Scripture, but it is quite challenging with the letters because they are correspondence.

This means that the letters are even more specifically located than some of the other literature in the Bible that assumes a more universal audience, such as Proverbs, Psalms, or the history books. Also, we only have half of the correspondence or "conversation," so we don't know what was written in response or even written first.

The process of reading a particular text that was written 2,000 years ago in a language that none of us speak to people who didn't live like us and applying that text to today in our cultural settings requires quite a lot of work!

We must situate the text in its context and try to work out what it meant to its original hearers and how they would have interpreted it. We must think through what the author might have meant back then and how it might have been received by the recipients. Based on that, we need to ask ourselves what does and doesn't apply directly to us. Then, if we believe something does apply, we need to think through what that looks like in our own world and what we should do about it.

The Hermeneutical Process

Translation, interpretation, reception, and application

The hermeneutical process happens on two levels—how this process was undergone in the ancient world (i.e., how Paul wrote and the Corinthians received and applied this letter) and the modern world (i.e., how we interpret, receive, and apply this letter) and how the two intersect.

We might intuitively feel that we know a lot about how the people in the first churches lived, but in fact, we know very little of their day-to-day lives. So we piece things together like a puzzle.

And in order to piece the puzzle together, we use scholarship and our imaginations. We construct a background from historical and archaeological discoveries as well as cross-referencing to other texts, which helps make sense of this text to us.

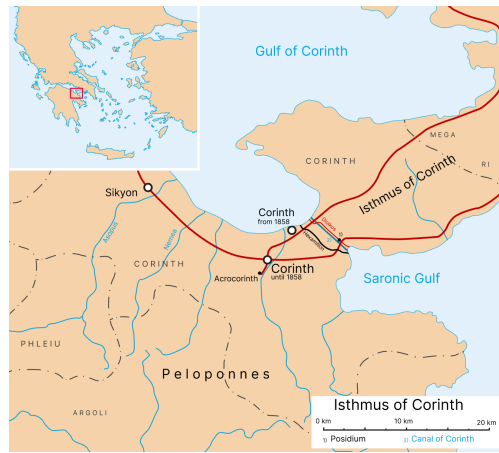
However, we can't escape making connections through what we already know. We read texts through our prior knowledge and experience, so we never come to them unencumbered. That's why we talk about "baggage."

First of all, we all need to admit that there are things we're going to bring to the text. We need to say, "Here's me with my background, my baggage, my expectations, and my preconceived ideas or prior assumptions."

What am I likely to hear if it's me listening to the text? And what might I miss?

The Setting: Ancient Corinth

Paul found himself in a significant city in Greece in the middle of the Roman Empire. Corinth still exists today, although new Corinth is a few miles northeast of old Corinth.



EcoChap (2011). Isthmus of Corinth. [Wikipedia](#).

Corinth was the political capital of the province of Achaia in the Roman Empire. It was destroyed in 146 B.C.E. as a result of a rebellion by the Greeks and rebuilt by Julius Caesar 100 years later, around 44 B.C.E., when it was founded as a Roman colony.

The Romans imposed new city plans, architecture, political organization, and ethos. These changes made it a very different city from when it had been Greek. Corinth was geographically in Greece but culturally Roman in terms of its religion and values, and it became a strategic and thriving third city after Rome and Alexandria.

As you can see on the map, it was very strategically placed, located between the Peloponnesus and mainland Greece. Corinth controlled the overland movement between Italy and Asia, and ships used to go through on rollers rather than taking the long water route around. As a port and a trade center, there was great wealth and also great poverty. In addition to this, there was also a thriving trade in prostitution as well as just general sexual license. It was known to be a place of sexual immorality.

Corinth was a thriving, multiethnic, multicultural port, and as a trade route, it was a wealthy city from tariffs and commerce. By the first century, Corinth had become the foremost commercial center in southern Greece. It was also the site of the Isthmian Games—a biennial athletic competition second only to the Olympic games.

Who did they worship? Corinth was influenced by the imperial cult (the emperor) and pagan worship (Roman and Greek gods and the Egyptian Isis cult).

Corinth was populated by Roman freedmen, indigenous Greeks, immigrants, and Jews, but it was a predominantly Roman city. People came to Corinth to settle and make money. They were not the aristocracy of the ancient world, but more “new money,” people who had made their wealth and who were moving up the social ladder.

Historical Context of the Letter

Three important questions to locate the text.

1. When was this written?
2. To whom was it written?

3. Why was it written?

It was definitely written by Paul. It is one of his earliest letters, and it was definitely written to the church in Corinth. Acts 18 gives us some historical background which helps us locate the letter.

- Gallio was the proconsul of Achaia, so that helps us to date the letter.
- Paul spent 18 months there on his second missionary journey in 49-51 C.E.
- The church was probably established in February or March 50 C.E. by Paul, but Silvanus (Silas) and Timothy also accompanied him (cf. 1 Thess. 1:1; 2 Cor. 1:19).

The Corinth Congregation

We think it was a congregation of about 50-100 people, and they would have met in homes.

When Paul arrived in Corinth, he went first to the Jews. He stayed with Priscilla and Aquila, who were also tentmakers like him and they worked together. As a port city, there would have been a need for tents, awnings, sails, and repairs. When Paul was rejected by the Jews, he moved on to stay with a Roman citizen, Titius Justus, who was a worshiper of God and whose house was next door to the synagogue (Acts 18:7).

Paul was in the middle of a thriving, ancient metropolis full of hustle and bustle. As he preached the Gospel to the Jews in the synagogue, he aggravated some of the Jews and they wanted him to be punished by Gallio, but Gallio refused. Paul escaped, and they beat Sosthenes instead. Then the Lord spoke to Paul in a vision one night and encouraged him to keep speaking and not stay silent. He promised Paul that he would be protected while he was in Corinth because the Lord had many people in the city (Acts 18:9-10). From this it seems that others evangelized Corinth before Paul—probably Priscilla and Aquila?

Paul planted a multicultural church in a multicultural city.

- Jews: Aquila, Priscilla, Crispus
- Romans: Fortunatus, Quartus, Justus
- Greeks: Stephanus, Achaica/us, Erastus

After 18 months, Paul left Corinth and set sail for Syria with Priscilla and Aquila. They landed in Ephesus where he stayed for a short time and then left but promised to return to them if God willed. Priscilla and Aquila stayed in Ephesus, and Paul went on to Caesarea, Jerusalem, and Antioch (Acts 18:18-22).

After ministering to the churches in Asia Minor, Paul then returned to Ephesus, where he stayed for two years. While he was there, he began to hear reports about the Corinthian church that caused him some concern. These reports from “Chloe’s people” inform him of divisions, jealousy, strife, and immorality within the church.

Paul has already written to them (we don’t know how many times), and they have written back at least once (1 Cor. 5:9-11). Paul probably wrote back to the Corinthians from Ephesus somewhere between 51-55 C.E. (scholars are not sure about the exact year). So the letter we call First Corinthians is actually second Corinthians or maybe even third. We don’t really know.

Paul is writing this letter primarily to correct them on both their thinking and their practices. This letter would have been read aloud in public to the whole church, maybe even multiple times.

Summary of the Letter

Paul's aim is to bring the Corinthian church to maturity in their thinking and practices.

The tone of his letter is a harsh admonishment for their departure from Paul's original teaching and practices, as well as a response to their reply to his original letter. Paul is writing to them regarding certain practices that have become acceptable or normative in his absence that he passionately disagrees with and wants to correct them on.

For the most part, Paul's corrections are not mild suggestions but forthright and authoritative directives.

"The whole first epistle was written ... not with ink but with gall. It is passionate, indignant, scornful, threatening, harsh; and with respect to each of its various charges, it is directed against certain individuals as chief offenders."

Tertullian (1959). [*Treatises on Penance. Ancient Christian Writers*](#) 28. Paulist. 90-91.

Gordon Fee also argues that 1 Corinthians is more than a mild corrective.

"[T]he language and style of 1 Corinthians are especially rhetorical and combative. Paul is taking them on at every turn. There is little to suggest that he is either informing or merely correcting; instead, he is attacking and challenging with all the weapons in his literary arsenal."

Fee, Gordon E. (1991). [*The First Epistle to the Corinthians*](#). Eerdmans. 5-6.

It is forceful, but not unkind.

1 Corinthians 4:14-15 NRSV

¹⁴ I am not writing this to make you ashamed, but to admonish you as my beloved children. ¹⁵ For though you might have ten thousand guardians in Christ, you do not have many fathers. Indeed, in Christ Jesus I became your father through the gospel.

So the purpose is to warn them, to save them, and to bring them to a mature, Christ-like path where they can be true witnesses to Jesus. And Paul touches on multiple issues.

1. Division among the leaders and the congregation and squabbles between them
2. Their understanding of the cross and the Spirit
3. Their understanding of apostleship and leadership, authority and power
4. Their view of themselves as the spiritual ones, or the "top dogs" in spiritual terms, and what that looked like
5. Their understanding of sex, marriage, and singleness
6. Food sacrificed to idols and visiting temples
7. Their understanding and practice of spiritual gifts and the work of the Holy Spirit among them
8. Legal disputes among believers, which they took to secular courts for arbitration
9. Their treatment of the poor and women
10. Their understanding of the resurrection, eternity, and what that means for life and the cosmos in the here and now

11. The relationship of Jesus to the Father, although the language in 1 Corinthians refers mostly to Christ and God

He addresses theological, ecclesiological, doctrinal, and pastoral issues. It's an extraordinary letter and an amazing window into the early church and into Paul. It's full of wisdom, correction, insights, and revelation about the nature of God, pastoral care, and even includes personal testimony from Paul.

The book is gritty, real, and honest, and, at times, we see Paul pouring out his heart. Paul is addressing friends—people he converted, lived with for 18 months, disciplined, raised up into leadership—who now in his absence have gone off the rails in particular ways. He wants to call them back to truth and sanity and to a healthy, functional, Christ-centered, and Spirit-filled community.

The book is also amazingly contemporary. 1 Corinthians touches on issues of self-image; identity; pride and insecurity; sex, marriage, and singleness; leadership; church gatherings; and theologies of man and woman.

It addresses practices in church such as how we handle the Lord's Supper and charismatic gifts. It explores what it means to love one another, as well as issues of inequality and injustice. It covers major doctrinal questions about the nature of God, the Trinity, Jesus Christ, the cross and the resurrection, and the work of the Spirit.

1 Corinthians speaks to us today. It speaks into our situations, our lives together, the way we run our churches, and the way we treat each other. It has a whole theology of the church and how Christians should or could engage with the world.

And the letter concludes with powerful statements about the centrality and non-negotiability of the resurrection of Christ. The resurrection is the foundation of the Christian faith and the foundation of the Christian life. 1 Corinthians gives us a totally uncompromising vision of what it means to declare that Jesus Christ is risen from the dead and that he alone is Lord.

Now we turn to an important backdrop.

Before We Begin: We Can't Know Everything

"[New Testament scholars] assume that the basic beliefs and practices of the first-century world within which the church members lived are relatively easy to establish and describe, and that consequently one can discover with a significant degree of certainty such things as the causes of conflict over the Lord's Supper in 1 Cor. 11 or the origins of the disagreement over the nature and necessity of the resurrection body in 1 Cor. 15."

Meggitt, Justin J. (2004). "Sources: Use, Abuse and Neglect: The Importance of Ancient Popular Culture." [*Christianity at Corinth: The Quest for the Pauline Church*](#). Ed. D. Horrell and E. Adams. Westminster John Knox Press. 242.

He also makes the point that we rely on elite sources.

"It is important to remember that for all the claims some scholars make, we still have no idea of some of the most basic features of Greek and Roman life in the first century as it would affect the Corinthians. If we do

not even know what a slave in Corinth would should we really be so confident in assuming we can know what they thought or how they may have been expected to behave in different social contexts?" Meggitt, Justin J. (2004). "Sources: Use, Abuse and Neglect: The Importance of Ancient Popular Culture." [*Christianity at Corinth: The Quest for the Pauline Church*](#). Ed. D. Horrell and E. Adams. Westminster John Knox Press. 252.

In addition to this, Paul evokes very strong reactions in people! He can command either great love and loyalty or great loathing. Very few people are indifferent to Paul. Some ignore him, some hate him, and some people think that he endorses everything they already think.

We are also capable of projecting onto him things we wish were true about him. We should come with some caution about what we don't know, but there are some things we do know.

Honor-Shame in an Honor-Shame Society

For material on honor-shame in general and particularly in Romans, see *Reading Romans with Eastern Eyes: Honor and Shame in Paul's Message and Mission* by Brad Vaughn (formerly Jackson Wu).

What does it mean to be in an honor-shame society?

When you're in an honor-shame society, the one thing you want to possess is honor, and the last thing you want to have is shame. Honor is a prized possession, and you will do anything to gain it and keep it.

Vaughn writes that when a whole culture is governed by the honor-shame paradigm, it is one where people have a "heightened sensitivity to honor-shame dynamics" and that these cultures are ones that have a particular stress on tradition, relationship, and hierarchy. "These three factors shape a person's social status or 'face'" (Vaughn, 2019).

In the ancient world, wealth and freedom were signs of honor. Giving publicly was something people aspired to.

The inscription to Junia Theodora at Corinth in 43 C.E. is a good example.

"The people of Patara (in Lycia) have decreed: Whereas Junia Theodora, a Roman resident in Corinth, a woman held in highest honour ... who copiously supplied from her own means many of our citizens with generosity, and received them in her home and in particular never ceased acting on behalf of our citizens in regard to any favour asked—the majority of citizens have gathered in assembly to offer testimony on her behalf. They agree to vote to commend her and urge her to increase her generosity towards the city in the knowledge that our people also would not cease in their good will and gratitude to her and would do everything for the excellence and the glory that she deserved."

Pleket 8, excerpts. Lefkowitz, Mary R. and Fant, Maureen B. (2016). [*Women's Life in Greece and Rome: A Source Book in Translation*](#). Bloomsbury Academic. 192.

This public giving linked to honor puts Jesus' commands about giving in private in context ([Matt. 6:3](#); [Luke 11:42-43](#)).

Greek, Roman, and Jewish Honor-Shame Codes

Greeks, Romans, and Jews had slightly different honor-shame codes. For example, in all three groups it was dishonorable to eat with certain people. The Romans and Greeks would not mix rich and poor, slave and free, sometimes men and women. The Jews would not mix with the Gentiles. However, Romans ate together with their wives, Greeks did not, and the Greeks and Romans had quite different standards with regard to sexual morality, homosexuality, and marriage which were altogether different from the Jews.

Jesus, of course, broke all the honor-shame codes and taboos spectacularly, which was why he was so deeply offensive. He had no regard for the honor-shame culture into which he was born when it came to who would eat with whom. He deliberately used the table and the people he shared meals with to make his point: women, prostitutes, tax collectors, the unclean. He redefined relationships, tradition, and hierarchies to spend time with the shameful and shamed himself in doing so.

In an honor-shame society, you could earn honor through:

- Patronage (giving large amounts of money to the upkeep of the city or a statue or a building)
- Marriage, wealth, what your household looked like
- Cultivation of connections
- Oratory (impressive public speaking)

Oratory Honor

The Romans and the Greeks both valued skillful oratory and rhetoricians (people who were clever with words). They both valued the “wise,” the philosophers. They also had a practice of following a great orator and becoming one of their disciples.

Stephen Pogoloff suggests that the division within the church at Corinth was related to rhetoric or cultural wisdom.

“In Hellenistic culture, perceptions of one’s rhetorical, cultural wisdom are an important determinate of status. Thus, the divisions were rivalries for the status of having the wisest teacher. ... We can make best sense of the text if we imagine the problems to have arisen not among the highest or lowest levels of society, but among those with social pretensions who were most concerned with gaining a greater share of honor and most sensitive to insults which brought shame.”

Pogoloff, Stephen (1992). [*Logos and Sophia: The Rhetorical Situation of 1 Corinthians*](#). Society of Biblical Literature. 237, 255.

Being a Christian would bring you into direct conflict with your cultural values in the ancient world. Paul thought it should! But the Corinthians were living with one foot, sometimes both feet, firmly planted in their own world. Jewish, Roman, and Greek cultures were all highly stratified, hierarchical, and boundaried cultures, and so was the church at Corinth.

The Corinthian Personalities

What were the people in the church like from what we can gather from the letter? They were gifted and spiritual, and Paul calls them the *pneumatikoi* (the “Spirit-people”), and we think they were also calling themselves that. They were not lacking in any spiritual gift and were clearly also arrogant, egotistical, divisive, hierarchical, and competitive. They were boastful, superior, and thought they were at the top of the spiritual mountain, even perhaps having reached angelic status.

And they were still deeply affected by their own honor-shame culture. The churches at Corinth had reverted to cultural norms of tradition, relationship, and hierarchy, which also meant segregation and division.

The Corinthian Church and Syncretism

In this letter, scholars see shades of influence from these thought worlds:

- Jewish wisdom theology
- Stoicism
- Cynicism
- Perhaps the beginnings of something like Gnosticism (proto-Gnosticism), but we’re not really sure

“Paul was responding to problems which were created by the influence of secular ethics or social conventions on this nascent Christian community. They may have crept into the church imperceptibly and grown with the passage of time.”

Winter, Bruce W. (2001). [*After Paul Left Corinth: The Influence of Secular Ethics and Social Change*](#). Wm. B. Eerdmans-Lightning Source (Illustrated edition). 4.

“Some or perhaps many Christians in Corinth still carried over into their Christian existence many of the cultural traits that characterized their pre-Christian culture, including attitudes of competitiveness, self-promotion, self-congratulation, and an over-valuing of ‘success.’”

Thiselton, Anthony (2006). “The Significance of Recent Research on 1 Corinthians.” *Neotestamentica* 40 (2). 327.

“The church is not a cohesive community but a club, whose meetings provide important moments of spiritual insight and exaltation, but do not have global implications of moral or social change. The Corinthians could gladly participate in this church as one segment of their lives. But the segment, however important, is not the whole and not the centre. Their perception of their church and of the significance of their faith could correlate well with a life-style which remained fully integrated in Corinthian society. ... Their religious ethos permits an involvement in the church which does not entail significant social and moral realignment.”

Barclay, John (1992). “Thessalonica and Corinth: Social Contrasts in Pauline Christianity.” *Journal for the Study of the New Testament*. 95.

But this was a matter of pride to them. “Their spirit-filled lives are not an early experience of the future; they simply consider themselves to have reached the heights of human potential” (Barclay, 1992).

But for Paul, what they are doing and how they are doing it is anathema. He says in 1 Corinthians 11:17, “Your meetings do more harm than good!”

Nevertheless, “To the Saints ...”

But given all this and the background in Corinth, he says this at the beginning of the letter.

1 Corinthians 1:2-3 NRSV

² To the church of God that is in Corinth, to those who are sanctified in Christ Jesus, called to be saints, together with all those who in every place call on the name of our Lord Jesus Christ, both their Lord and ours: ³ Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

1 Corinthians 1:2 The Message

I send this letter to you in God’s church at Corinth, believers cleaned up by Jesus and set apart for a God-filled life.

Reflection Question

We read texts through our prior knowledge and experience, so we never come to any text unencumbered or without “baggage.” What are some of your expectations, preconceived ideas, or prior assumptions about 1 Corinthians? What impressions of Paul as a man, apostle, or pastor are you bringing into this class?